

Adding MAGIC to Linux

If you think Linux is for geeks and you need to dabble in command prompts, scripts and cryptic commands to get your machine started, Mandrake 8.2 will give you something else to think about

Mandrake 8.2 is a desktop operating system that can take on the likes of Windows without skipping a beat. Mandrake has evolved over the years into a comprehensive package that can perform the day-to-day tasks of most users without needing to use the command prompt. It now includes Ximian's Evolution 1.02, an 'Outlook clone' that contains an e-mail client and a rather extensive personal information manager. The new KDE 2.2.2 desktop features a much improved Konqueror browser and file manager and an integrated KOffice 1.1.1 office suite. New desktop features include a completely redesigned Mandrake Control Center that serves as a central location for Mandrake-specific tools and utilities, as well as many new easy-to-use configuration wizards. Desktop users will appreciate the task-oriented menus in KDE, which greatly simplify locating applications by categorising them. All in all, Mandrake 8.2 promises to be a wonderful alternative OS and a great starting point for new Linux users. With a simple, efficient and very intuitive interface along with an easy install process and a strong focus on the desktop, Mandrake 8.2 has every chance of cultivating a new breed of Linux-savvy users. In this article we'll evaluate its merits and nuances, and show you how you can install this OS on your computer. You can then decide for yourself whether you want to join the Free Software movement.

Installation

The installation of Linux distributions has improved tremendously over the years and Mandrake has probably the

simplest possible installation amongst them all.

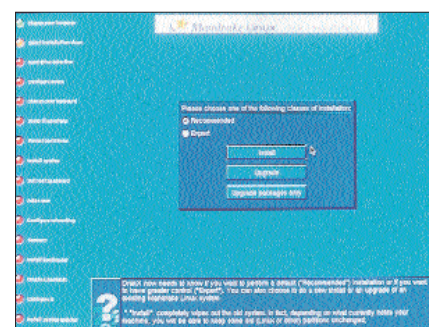
Basics: Before you install Mandrake 8.2, in the BIOS, change the first boot device from your hard drive to the CD-ROM. Now insert the bootable Mandrake 8.2 CD in the CD-ROM drive and restart the PC; the installation will now start automatically. Follow the onscreen instructions and choose the language in which the OS will be set up. English is selected by default, click 'Accept' for the license agreement and continue. Next, you will be presented with

the option of 'Recommended installation' or an 'Expert installation'. If you are new to Linux, opt for 'Recommended installation'. If you have used Mandrake or any other Linux distribution before, you can choose 'Expert installation' and further customise your installation.

Partitioning: We now come to probably the most critical part of the installation. The screen will show the number of partitions and the number of drives installed

Hits and Misses

- 👍 Rock solid Linux 2.4.18 kernel
- 👍 Superb menu system using the integrated Menudrake
- 👍 The all new Control Center for simple settings and configuration of components
- 👍 DiskDrake for all your partitioning needs (JFS, XFS, ReiserFS, Ext3 and Encrypted Filesystems)
- 👍 Excellent Multimedia (Xine!) and peripheral support
- 👍 URPMI—the graphical RPM installer rocks and is a lot faster
- 👍 Loads of games
- 👎 No troubleshooting wizards for newbies
- 👎 KDE 3.0 RC2 is not included in Mandrake 8.2
- 👎 The fonts are still uninspiring
- 👎 KDE is very sluggish at times and can get a little taxing for low-end machines



Select 'Expert installation' if you've used Linux before

on your system. If you have a hard drive with only one partition that has Windows installed on it, then Mandrake will display it as a FAT partition (it will be displayed as a dark blue band). If there is more than one partition then it will show blocks, each representing one partition.

Click on the partition or drive on which you want to install Mandrake 8.2 and click 'Auto allocate'. This option simplifies your work; you won't have to create mount points or assign separate swap partitions. Enabling this option will ensure that the total available size is automatically allocated for swap and native partitions. It will automatically create a total of three partitions: two native Linux partitions (Ext3) with different mount points and one